



Fishing

Sea fish have been part of our diet for thousands of years, and in some parts of the world, traditional techniques continue to be used to harvest enough fish to meet the local demand. Far greater quantities of fish can be caught using boats and nets, and so sea fishing has now become a major industry involving big ships supported by advanced technology. However, overfishing can threaten the stocks of some species. An alternative is to farm the fish, shellfish, and other types of seafood, which does not destroy wild fish stocks.



TRADITIONAL METHODS

These Fijian fishermen are using a net supported by floats to encircle a small school of fish in shallow water near the shore. People living on sea coasts have always used simple ways of catching fish, such as hand-worked nets, baited lines, and spears.

INSHORE FISHING

Many coastal communities have fleets of small fishing boats that go to sea for a few hours, and return each day to unload their catch. The fishermen use simple nets and lines, and if they catch just enough fish to supply local markets, they have little impact on fish stocks.

► A GOOD CATCH

With the fleet lying safely at harbor, villagers collect the morning catch that has been brought in by the fishermen in Mui Ne on the central south coast of Vietnam.



FARMING SHELLFISH

Clams, limpets, and other wild shellfish have probably been harvested since humans first walked on Earth, but many shellfish are also well suited to being farmed. Mussels in particular naturally attach themselves to rocks and other hard surfaces. They will readily cling to timber piles, rafts, and ropes provided for them, and will gather their own food. Mussels are also very easy to harvest when their supports are exposed at low tide.

◀ MUSSEL FARM

Ropes wound around posts on this French beach support thousands of farmed mussels.